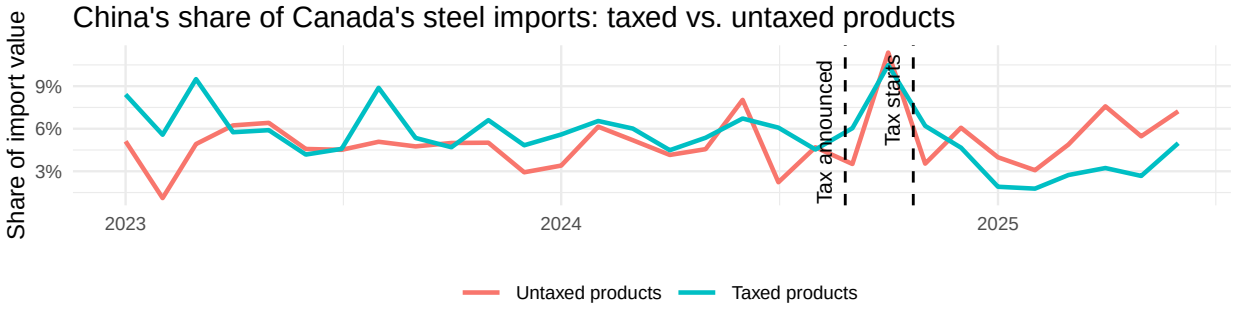
Did Canada's 2024 Tariff on Chinese Steel Change Where Canada Buys Its Steel?

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The question. In October 2024, Canada added a 25% tax on steel from China. When one supplier becomes more expensive, buyers tend to switch to others. Did China's share of Canada's steel imports fall, and was the tax the reason, rather than seasons, price changes, long-term trends or the trade dispute with the United States that began in 2025?

What I did. I used Statistics Canada's monthly import records for 167 types of steel products from January 2023 to August 2026. The tax covered 130 of these products and not the other 37. The key test compares how China's share changed for taxed products with how it changed for untaxed products over the same months: if the tax was responsible, the drop should show up mainly in the taxed group. I also checked the same season a year apart, imports by weight, and whether the two groups were already moving apart before the tax.



What I found.

- **China's share fell.** It dropped from 5.9% before the tax to 3.7% in the four months after it started. The drop also shows up by weight and remains when comparing the same winter months a year apart. Imports from China themselves fell by about 39%.
- **The drop was mainly in taxed products.** Before the tax, China's shares in the two groups moved together. Afterwards, its share of taxed products fell to about 2-3%, while its share of untaxed products returned to its usual range.
- **The size of the effect: about 2 percentage points.** China's share of taxed products fell by about 1.9 points more than its share of untaxed products, roughly a third of its earlier share. Including months up to June 2025 gives a larger drop of about 3.1 points, but that period overlaps with the U.S. dispute.
- **Who gained.** Comparing taxed and untaxed products for each supplier, Japan is the most likely gainer, though the evidence is not conclusive. For the United States and smaller suppliers, the data are too noisy to tell.

How sure can we be? Only four months separate the tax from the 2025 trade dispute, so the result rests on very little data. Whether it clears the usual bar for statistical significance depends on how uncertainty is measured; in a product-by-product comparison its likely range includes zero, and if a slow drift in the gap before the tax is assumed to have continued, most of the effect disappears. The evidence is suggestive rather than conclusive, and a smaller Chinese share does not by itself show that the tax was good for Canada.

What this means for decision-makers. For *importers and buyers*: the clearest sign of where the business went is Japan, and tracking supplier shares product by product, comparing taxed with untaxed products, can reveal such shifts within months. For *policymakers*: the tax appears to have cut China's share of covered products by about a third, but four months of clean data cannot show its full effect, and the costs to Canadian buyers are not measured.

Full report and R code: https://github.com/betterandy24/canada-steel-surtax